

of followers a person can maintain. What can you, as a social media manager, do so that the focus stays on quality content and not a fetishisation of validation by numbers? Let's look at a few examples for context.

In November 2015, Essena O'Neill, an Australian teenager, decided that she had had enough of social media's obsession with turning human lives into popularity contests. With over half a million Instagram followers, she was a fairly successful Instagram model, being paid hundreds of dollars for featuring clothes and health drinks in her posts. However, her epiphany included the realisation that the sacrifices she had to make just to make her life seem appealing for the sake of online fame were just not worth it. She took down over 2000 images that she'd posted in the past, and recaptioned a few pictures explaining her decision, stating that she'd spent the majority of her teenage life addicted to social media, and that such a system, based on social approval and validation is nothing more than "self-absorbed judgement."

In September 2015, Chompoo Baritone, a Bangkok-based photographer, released a series of photographs illustrating just how easy it is to project an illusion of the perfect life made up of the perfect moments. Headstands being assisted by a cleverly-positioned helping hand just out of the frame, cropping out the busy crowd for that serene-looking picture at the beach - shoving all the clutter on the bed to one side just to get that perfect shot of Sunday-morning-coffee-and-Macbook-session - these are just some of the startling examples that Baritone shows in her series.

The takeaway from this as a social media manager should be that your responsibility should consist of keeping the focus fixed on your brand's content and its quality. The idea is to promote and advertise your brand in a healthy manner, where likes and followers are merely metrics which should always take secondary priority to your real objective - your customers.

Like with any social media platform, Instagram comes with its flaws and deceptions. Keep your target audience at the top of your priority and you'll reap the rewards. Get sucked into a mindless numbers game to try and make it a beauty pageant, and your brand will perish. 